

A Stranger Comes to Town

George tipped down the morning's paper to glare at the blindingly white sun hat across the street. The stranger was out in his front lawn again, working on his garden of heliotropes and crab blossoms. He had only moved in a few weeks ago and he'd already drawn the ire of the community by failing to be part of it. George had heard that Patty Hutchinson tried bringing the man a homemade ice cream cake the day after he arrived and he turned it down! Poor Patty had to eat the whole thing herself before it melted. On top of that, he had yet to introduce himself to anyone in the community; no welcome wishes, no church attendances, not even an appearance at the monthly town hall.

George indignantly pulled the paper back up to his eye level as his wife walked out onto the front porch, looking out at the newcomer as she handed George his morning coffee.

"I wonder if he ever gets out of that yard," she pondered aloud. George scoffed as he took a sip of his coffee.

"I doubt the sap even has a job," he spat. Helen looked at him, a little displeased at his rudeness, before continuing.

"You should try and talk to him, I'm worried he spends too much time out there in the hot sun. I've seen him talking to himself out there a couple times even," she said. George grumbled to himself, knowing no matter how hard he argued, his wife was already set on him going over there.

"Why should I go over there? So he can dismiss me like he did to Patty and Leo and everyone else who tried to make his acquaintance? No thank you." Helen kicked his foot softly, and George had to steady his hand to avoid spilling his coffee. "Alright alright fine, I'll talk to the old man," George said, placing down his mug and paper as he sauntered across the street to the stranger's home, hoping the smell of his gaudy garden didn't disagree with his sensitive nose. As George approached the white picket fence surrounding the stranger's home, he saw the sunhat tilt upwards to reveal the face of an older man in his 40's, the same as George, hair peppered with streaks of gray and stubble crawling its way up to the base of his bottom lip. George smiled at the man as a sign of good faith, but the man's only response was to look back down at flowers he was watering. "Asshole," George mumbled under his breath.

As his feet crossed the threshold of the fence George felt an odd presence surrounding him, though he figured it was most likely the overwhelming smell of balsamic and sandalwood. He stood there for a moment, waiting for the stranger to approach him given it was his lawn they were standing in, but it seemed the new neighbor had no respect for the community's long held custom of hostship.

"Good morning neighbor!" George called out in a welcoming tone, hoping to catch the man's attention. The stranger glanced up at him, his knees deep in the dirt as he pulled out a lock of crabgrass from the base of one of his plants. "I just wanted to say hello and properly welcome you to the neighborhood! I'm sure you've seen me out on the porch before, but I'm George

Swanson. That's my wife Helen up there," he said, pointing up to his front porch where his wife sat. The stranger didn't bother looking up from the soil as he pulled out another patch of weeds. George held himself, trying not to scold the old man for his unmannerly behavior, before switching up his approach.

"So neighbor, I haven't gotten the chance to meet your family. I know you've all probably been busy with the move so I get it, but if you got kids I would highly recommend enrolling them in Count Bradley, my own kids go there and they-"

"I don't got no kids," the stranger interrupted George mid sentence, taking him aback. The man's voice was gruff, not too dissimilar to George's, though much harsher than George had ever remembered being after his 20's. Despite the standoffish retort, George was proud he at least got the man to speak to him.

"Oh, well I suppose that's why your house is always so quiet," George said in an attempt to lighten the mood, "Do you-"

"I don't have no wife neither," the stranger said before George could even ask his question.

"I suppose you're probably thankful to not have the ol' ball and chain holding you back huh?" George said with a half chuckle, "Lemme guess, she was allergic to flowers?"

"She left after our son died," the man said bluntly. George instantly piped down, realizing how bad he had just messed up. He glanced back up to his wife on the porch, signaling to her that the introduction wasn't going well.

"Oh goodness, I'm so sorry to hear that. I... I really do hope you're doing alright, neighbor. I mean... we do have a community group that meets at the church on Thursday nights to talk about stuff like that. My grandfather died a few years back and going to the group really helped me to heal after that..." George stumbled through his words, desperate to try and heal the stranger's unfortunate wound he had inadvertently reopened.

"No need to apologize, Mr. Swanson. I know I spend a lot of time out here in the garden which may seem strange, but it's how I stay close to my boy. It's like he's still here with me when I water the flowers." To George's surprise, the man gave a small smile, tilting the watering can beside him to feed his flora. George admittedly felt rather bad for how he judged the man up until now, he was a loner sure, but it wasn't out of any malicious attempt at rudeness or incompassion, he was just a grieving father. The two spoke for a bit longer, the stranger revealing his name to be Langston, and George telling him about the community's spring festival coming up in a few days. George was happy as the two said goodbye, turning to leave the sweet aroma of the garden. As he did however, he felt that sense of oddness come over him again, realizing that the purple heliotrope flowers beside him seemed to be leaning in his direction, despite the very apparent lack of wind. Their petals faced him, the black dots in the center of the flower feeling like eyes piercing through his soul. His pace quickened, feeling a little uncomfortable at the strange sway of the flowers, but before he fully left the range of Langston's house, he could hear the man seemingly muttering something to his garden as he lifted up the watercan to feed it once more.

“Leave him alone boy... you’ve got a ways to grow before you’ll be ready...”